Prompt Engineering for Beginners

Most people talk to AI the same way they'd type a Google search — and wonder why the results feel generic, wrong, or just… off. This presentation changes that.

10-SLIDE COURSE

BEGINNER FRIENDLY

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Why Most Prompts Fail

The **Prompt Problem** is real — and it's not the AI's fault.

Too Vague

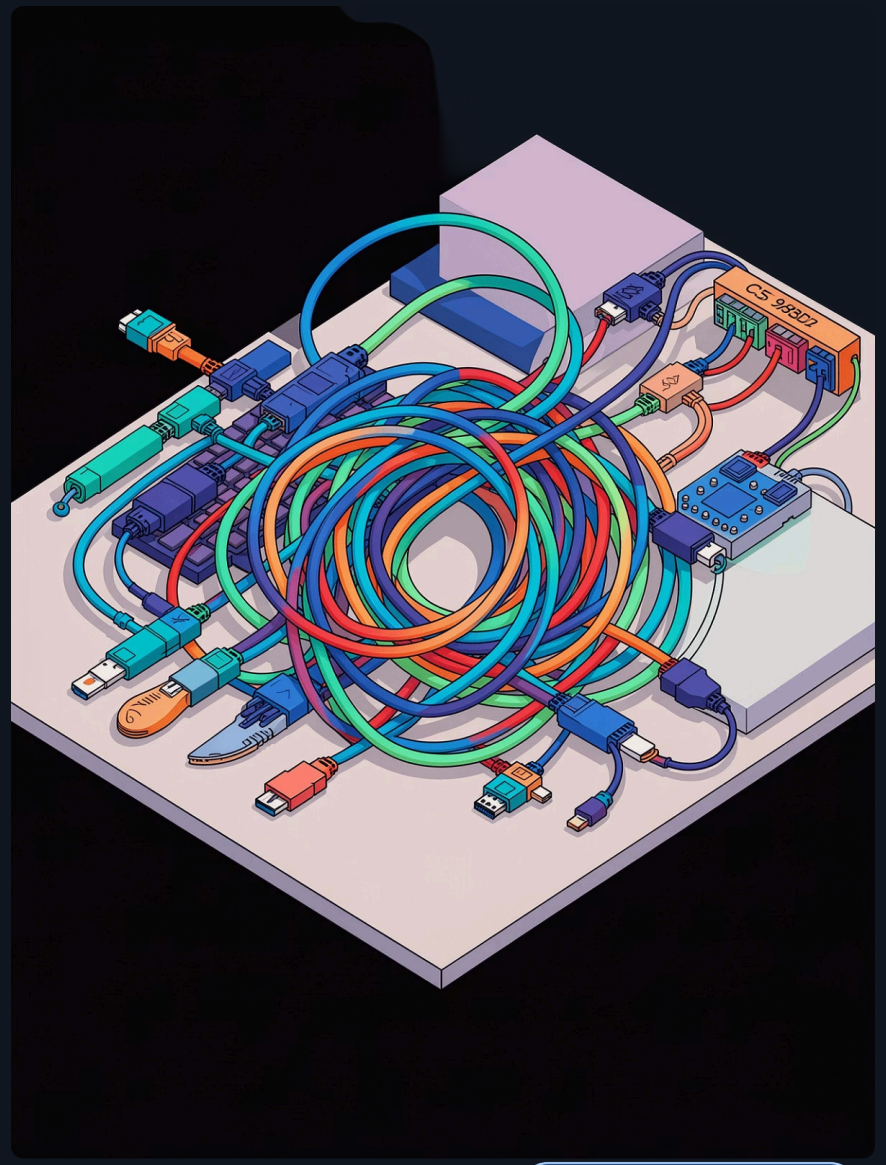
"Write me something about marketing" gives the AI no direction. You get a five-paragraph essay that helps no one.

No Context

Without background, the AI makes assumptions — often wrong ones. Garbage in, garbage out.

No Format

If you don't specify how you want the answer structured, you'll get whatever the model decides — and it won't match your workflow.



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What Is a Prompt?

Simple Definition

A **prompt** is any text you give to an AI model to produce a response. Think of it as your instruction — the clearer it is, the better the output.

Technical Definition

Prompts are natural language inputs that guide a large language model (LLM) to generate a specific, contextually relevant output based on learned patterns.

Every chat message, command, or question you send to an AI is a prompt. You're already doing it — let's do it better.

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The Teacher Analogy

Imagine a substitute teacher given only one sentence: *"Teach the class something."* Compare that to a detailed lesson plan.

❌ Vague Teacher Note

"Teach them math." — The substitute has no grade level, no topic, no materials. Chaos ensues.

✅ Detailed Lesson Plan

"Teach 7th graders how to solve two-step equations using real-world examples. Keep it under 30 minutes." — Clear, scoped, actionable.

Your AI prompt **is** the lesson plan. The more guidance you provide, the better the "teaching" you receive.

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Anatomy of a Great Prompt

Every strong prompt has four core ingredients. Think of them as your prompt blueprint.

Role

Tell the AI *who* to be.
"Act as a senior UX designer..."

Context

Provide the *why* and *what*. Include background, audience, and goals.

Constraints

Set boundaries.
"Keep it under 150 words. Avoid jargon."

Format

Specify the structure.
"Return a bulleted list / table / JSON..."

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Good Prompt vs. Bad Prompt

❌ WEAK PROMPT

> "Write about social media."

Output: A generic 500-word essay covering every social platform in existence — useful to no one, actionable to no one.

✅ STRONG PROMPT

> "You are a social media strategist. Write 3 LinkedIn post ideas for a B2B SaaS startup targeting HR managers. Each post should be under 100 words and use a hook + insight + CTA format."

Output: Three targeted, ready-to-use posts that match the audience, platform, and goal perfectly.

The difference? Role + Context + Constraints + Format. Four ingredients. Infinite improvement.

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The 3 Pillars of Prompt Engineering

Clarity

Use simple, direct language. Eliminate ambiguity. If a human would be confused by your instructions, so will the AI.

Specificity

Add details that matter — audience, tone, length, examples. Specific prompts generate specific, usable results.

Iteration

Great prompts are rarely written perfectly the first time. Refine, test, and improve based on what the AI returns.

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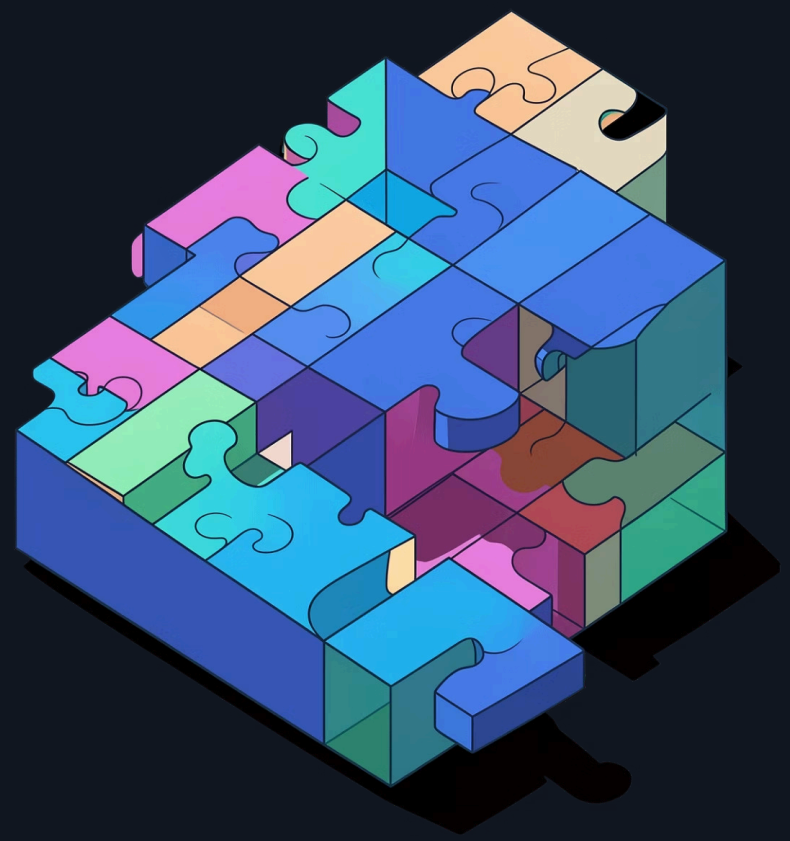

Practice: Fix This Vague Prompt

Put your skills to the test. How would *you* improve this prompt?

> "Help me with my presentation."

🎯 Add a Role

Who should the AI be? A designer? A coach? A copywriter?

📋 Add Context

What's the topic? Who's the audience? What's the goal of the presentation?

📐 Add Format

Do you want slide titles? Speaker notes? A full outline? A summary?

Try it: Rewrite the prompt above using Role + Context + Constraints + Format. Share with a partner and compare results!

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Common Pitfalls to Avoid

🌀 Hallucinations

AI can confidently state **false information**. Vague prompts increase this risk. Always verify facts and cite sources independently.

🔒 Over-Constraining

Too many restrictions leave the AI no room to work. If your prompt has 20 rules, expect confused or incomplete output. **Balance is key.**

🔁 No Iteration

Treating the first output as final is the most common mistake. Build a habit of **refining your prompt** based on what didn't work.

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Quick Knowledge Check

Test what you've learned with these two questions:

1

Which prompt is most effective?

A) "Write a blog post."
B) "Write a 600-word blog post for beginner runners on how to avoid shin splints. Use a friendly tone and include 3 actionable tips."
✅ **Answer: B** — It includes role, context, constraints, and format.

2

What should you do if an AI output is off?

A) Accept it and move on.
B) Switch to a different AI tool.
C) Refine your prompt and try again.
✅ **Answer: C** — Iteration is the third pillar of great prompting.

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